

The Perceived Fit between Instagram Influencers and the Endorsed Brand

How Influencer–Brand Fit Affects

Source Credibility and Persuasive Effectiveness

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Two online studies analyzed the impact of the fit between Instagram influencers and the endorsed brand. The first study used an experimental design and focused on internal validity, whereas the second study employed a survey, presenting results high in external validity. Both studies analyzed the consequences for the influencer concerning his/her perceived trustworthiness and expertise, as well as the impact on brand evaluations and behavioral intentions. Influencer–brand fit had a positive impact on the image of the influencer and on the effectiveness of advertising, especially for followers with low levels of parasocial relationships.

INTRODUCTION

Facebook, Instagram, WeChat, and Twitter are examples of social-media platforms that have millions of daily users (Kemp, 2018). Social trends and technological progress have paved the way for the ubiquitous use of social media, and further growth is predicted. In terms of the numbers of users and overall time spent on social media, social-media usage is increasing steadily. Approximately three

billion people worldwide now use social media monthly, 90 percent of whom access their chosen platforms on mobile devices (Chahal, 2016; Kemp, 2018).

In observing these tendencies, some advertising specialists cautiously are starting to turn their backs on traditional media, such as print and broadcasting, to prefer online (and especially mobile) social media as advertising vehicles (eMarketer, 2017).

Management Slant

- The fit of influencer and brand product is important for the perceived expertise and trustworthiness of the endorser. To avoid damaging their credibility, influencers should avoid endorsing obviously incongruent brands.
- If social-media influencers wish to promote a brand that might be slightly incongruent, they should create a particularly personal post (e.g., incorporating a personal story or addressing their followers very directly) to generate high levels of parasocial interaction and to strengthen parasocial relationships.
- A strong influencer–brand fit increases consumers' brand attitudes and behavioral intentions, both directly and indirectly through the influencer's perceived credibility. Advertising specialists should select social-media influencers that match the brand.
- If brand managers want to use an influencer who is not a perfect match to target new potential consumers explicitly or to change their brand image, they should use someone who has a very strong connection with their audience, because followers who report strong parasocial relationships are less skeptical.

Submitted June 12, 2018;
revised October 31, 2018;
accepted February 13, 2019.

Opportunities to integrate brands and brand products through online channels appear extensive. Banner advertising, integration into users' social-media feeds, and video prerolls are just a few examples of popular advertising spaces sold by online media channels.

Because of the general tendency of consumers to avoid or disregard advertisements, some of the social-media advertising potential seems wasted. Advertisement blockers and general advertising avoidance or banner blindness inhibit effectiveness, diminishing the return on investment (DeVeirman, Cauberghe, and Hudders, 2017). A popular way to avoid media users' reactance or disregard is to integrate the advertisements into the actual content of the media (*i.e.*, branded entertainment) or to adjust the advertisement toward the media vehicle with regard to both content and design (*i.e.*, native advertising; Evans, Phua, Lim, and Jun, 2017; Hudson and Hudson, 2006). The rise of social media offers new methods for implementing these strategies.

Social-Media Influencers

A novel form of social-media advertising has gained popularity in recent years. The use of social-media influencers to promote brands has gained traction, with 86 percent of surveyed marketers using influencer marketing in 2017 (Linqia, 2018). Social-media influencers are defined as opinion leaders in digital social media who communicate to an unknown mass audience (Gräve, 2017) and are regarded as "trusted tastemaker[s] in one or several niches" (DeVeirman *et al.*, 2017, p. 798). Instagram is considered the most important social network for influencer marketing, followed by Facebook (Linqia, 2018).

Social-media influencers incorporate brands into their feeds, and, even though they legally are required to provide an adequate indication of the persuasive

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nature of their messages (*e.g.*, using "#sponsored" or "#ad"), followers readily accept their recommendations (Boerman, Willemsen, and van der Aa, 2017). Influencer marketing has been described as a type of native advertising, branded entertainment, or highly credible electronic word of mouth, because the commercial posts usually are woven seamlessly into the daily narratives that social-media influencers share with their followers (DeVeirman *et al.*, 2017; Evans *et al.*, 2017; Hudson and Hudson, 2006).

The Challenge of Choosing The Best-Suited Influencer

Although this new form of advertising sounds promising, advertising specialists might be overwhelmed by the extensive offerings made by influencer agencies. Thousands of different influencers are available, offering divergent topical interests, numbers of followers, and other characteristics (Swant, 2016). The challenging decision that brand managers must face is the choice of the best-suited and most effective influencer (Chahal, 2016; DeVeirman *et al.*, 2017).

The perception of which influencer is the best-suited endorser may vary depending on the particular goals of a brand. Volvo, for example, paid Chriselle Lim to feature their brand in several of her posts, even though she is a fashion

and lifestyle influencer who previously had shown absolutely no interest in cars (Curalate, 2016). Volvo most likely wanted to reach Lim's one million Instagram followers and engage them as potential new consumers while also revitalizing their brand image.

On the basis of the general assumption that social-media influencers are more credible and authentic than are regular endorsers (Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017), some advertisers might think that a mismatch between a brand and a social-media influencer is not overly detrimental. Volvo's campaign, however, was criticized quite heavily and had negative effects for both the influencer and the brand. Chriselle Lim explicitly posted an apology to appease her followers, who were quite upset (Curalate, 2016), and Volvo was called out for poor influencer strategy (Salzman, 2016).

This is an extreme example that often has been referred to as an "unsuccessful influencer case study" (Kurdej, 2017), and the general agreement in advertising is to choose congruent endorsers (Sipka, 2017). It would be relevant to know, however, whether a slight mismatch would have the same negative consequences that have been reported in studies of regular endorsement (Amos, Holmes, and Strutton, 2008; Bergkvist and Zhou, 2016) or whether social-media influencers'

generally high credibility could compensate for this kind of mismatch (Chung and Cho, 2017). This information would be of interest to companies that wish to engage new potential customers or alter their brand image and also for influencers, who might be offered lucrative partnerships by incongruous brands.

Because of the novelty of the topic, it has undergone little scientific investigation, and related research areas, such as celebrity endorsement, should be considered cautiously. Although social-media influencers often are perceived as stars by their followers and frequently are labeled as “Instafamous” (Evans *et al.*, 2017) or as “YouTube celebrities” (Lee and Watkins, 2016), they can and should be distinguished from traditional celebrity endorsers, such as actors, musicians, and athletes, who provide commercial content on social media. This is the case for two reasons.

First, there are differences in their patterns of emergence; in contrast to traditional celebrities, who gain their popularity through institutional settings, social-media influencers capture their audience without any institutional mediation (Gräve, 2017; McQuarrie, Miller, and Phillips, 2012). Second, several advertising experts and researchers consider the information provided by social-media influencers to be more credible, relatable, and authentic, compared with that provided by traditional celebrities (Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017), as long as the influencer is in line with the brand (Chahal, 2016) and the media user perceives the influencer as familiar (Gräve, 2017).

LITERATURE REVIEW

The novelty of the topic of social-media influencers means that few studies have analyzed the impact of specific elements on influencer likability and advertising effectivity. Research results are important for both the social-media influencers and

the brands. In contrast to regular endorsers, such as actors or musicians, influencers have to rely on their social-media channels to reach their audience (Gräve, 2017). They cannot generate a positive image through successful movies or popular concerts. Their actions on social media are crucial for gaining new followers and keeping existing ones engaged with their content.

As found in previous studies of endorsement, the image of the celebrity endorser is of great importance to the effectivity of an advertising campaign (Amos *et al.*, 2008; McCracken, 1989). A bad image quickly can harm the associated brand (Campbell and Warren, 2012). Most of the following studies consequently have examined the effects of divergent elements on perceptions of both the influencer and the brand.

One study examined the influence of YouTube video bloggers (*i.e.*, “vloggers”) on perceptions of luxury brands (Lee and Watkins, 2016). That study incorporated the concept of parasocial interactions, which represent the nonreciprocal cognitive, affective, and conative interactions of media users with the media personality (Horton and Wohl, 1956; Schramm and Hartmann, 2008). One research group conducted three consecutive studies and validated perceived similarity and social attractiveness as suitable determinants for the strength of the parasocial interactions (Lee and Watkins, 2016). These determinants, in turn, had a significant positive impact on both affective and behavioral brand dimensions.

Two other research groups analyzed the impact of social-media influencers by manipulating different elements of the influencers’ Instagram posts (DeVeirman *et al.*, 2017; Evans *et al.*, 2017). One group (Evans *et al.*, 2017) varied the disclosure language, using the persuasion-knowledge model (Friestad and Wright, 1994) as a theoretical foundation. If media users were aware of the persuasive intention and also

remembered the disclosure, then their attitudes and intentions to share the post were reduced significantly (Evans *et al.*, 2017).

The other study analyzed the impact of influencers’ numbers of followers and followers on attitudes toward the influencer and the advertised brand (DeVeirman *et al.*, 2017). The number of followers positively affected the influencer’s likability through perceived popularity and opinion leadership, whereas a proportionally very high or very low number of followers reduced the influencer’s likability and perceived opinion leadership. Another relevant finding was that brands with an unusual or exclusive image should favor influencers with a moderate number of followers to strengthen the brand’s unique image.

The researchers (DeVeirman *et al.*, 2017) used the results of their studies to identify practical implications regarding the selection of influencers, but they noted that future researchers should analyze additional elements to ensure comprehensive practical advice on the selection criteria. They actively stressed the importance of researching the impact of the fit between the brand and the influencer, with reference to the match-up hypothesis (Baker and Churchill, 1977; Friedman and Friedman, 1979; Kamins, 1990).

The effect of congruency between the brand endorser and the endorsed brand has been the theme of investigations into various advertising forms, including celebrity endorsements (Amos *et al.*, 2008) and brand placements (Balasubramanian, Karrh, and Patwardhan, 2006; Karrh, 1998; Knoll, Schramm, Schallhorn, and Wynnistorf, 2015). Although mainly positive effects of congruency have been found in the context of traditional celebrities and media characters (*e.g.*, Amos *et al.*, 2008; Knoll *et al.*, 2015), the situation might be different for social-media-influencer advertising. It could be either especially important or neglectable.

The match-up hypothesis states that endorsers are more effective if they fit, match, or are congruent with the advertised brand.

On the one hand, the impact of perceived fit, match-up, or congruency should be highly relevant for influencer marketing, because this type of marketing often is experienced as regular communication without persuasive intentions (Evans *et al.*, 2017). If media users notice a mismatch between the brand and the influencer, such as Chriselle Lim's Volvo endorsement, they might stumble cognitively over the unsuitable affiliation and consequently perceive the influencer and his or her message to be less credible, recognizing the persuasive and commercial intent (Koernig and Boyd, 2009).

On the other hand, however, the special characteristics of social-media influencers might diminish the importance of the perceived fit. Given the numerous interactions and the personal communication between the social-media influencer and his or her followers, the perceived interpersonal connection might overshadow other elements. Social-media influencers might be perceived as credible even if they endorse a slightly incongruent brand.

Because influencers and brand managers both should aim for high credibility concerning their social-media content, this article focuses on the impact of perceived fit on influencer credibility and the consequent effects on brand attitudes and behavioral intentions concerning the advertised brand. The authors conducted two studies with different priorities. The first employed an experimental design with high internal validity. In this study, the authors manipulated the fit of the influencer and the brand and analyzed its connection to source credibility, brand

attitudes, and behavioral intentions. The first study therefore was meant to analyze whether the congruency between social-media influencers and brand product is important for influencer marketing in general.

In a different approach, the second study focused on the external validity of the results. Existing studies have used single Instagram posts, short video web logs, or different kinds of media stimuli from unknown or fictive endorsers and brands as material for their studies (*e.g.*, DeVirman *et al.*, 2017; Evans *et al.*, 2017; Koernig and Boyd, 2009; Lee and Watkins, 2016; Till and Busler, 2000). In the real world, however, followers generally subscribe to the influencer's channel for several weeks, months, or years and consequently establish intense parasocial relationships (Yuksel and Labrecque, 2016). A one-time contact therefore hardly can reproduce realistic effects. The authors of the aforementioned studies on the impact of social-media influencers themselves have acknowledged the limitations of this part of their methodological approach and have argued in support of higher external validity (DeVirman *et al.*, 2017; Evans *et al.*, 2017; Lee and Watkins, 2016).

In the second study, therefore, the authors used a survey to analyze the impact of existing influencers on their actual followers, incorporating long-term parasocial relationships into the theoretical model of the first study. This should be especially important to ascertain the impact of perceived fit on influencer credibility in a more natural setting. Before describing the methods and the results of

both studies in detail, the authors present the theoretical foundation.

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

Two recent meta-analyses summarized the effects of celebrity endorsement, providing a quantitative synthesis of the effect sizes presented in more than 30 years of endorsement literature (Amos *et al.*, 2008; Bergkvist and Zhou, 2016). The authors of these meta-analyses identified the critical predictors of endorsement effectiveness, stressing the importance of the fit between the endorser and the product as well as the perceived source credibility.

The Match-Up Hypothesis

The match-up hypothesis states that endorsers are more effective if they fit, match, or are congruent with the advertised brand. One study (Mishra, Roy, and Bailey, 2015) used social-adaptation theory and attributional theory as a theoretical background to support this claim. Social-adaptation theory predicts that endorsers will be perceived as an effective source of new information if their personality seems congruent with the promoted brand image (Kamins, 1990; Mishra *et al.*, 2015). Attractive celebrities, for instance, should serve as an adequate source concerning beauty products, because consumers might believe that the product's use could enhance their own attractiveness (Kahle and Homer, 1985; Kamins, 1990).

Attributional theory suggests that consumers might believe that the endorser is internally motivated, rather than externally motivated, when promoting a fitting brand (Mishra *et al.*, 2015). Consumers should think that endorsers who seem to match the brand are promoting it because they like or use it, not because of an endorsement fee or advertising contract (Koernig and Boyd, 2009). In line with this prediction, another study (Till and Busler, 2000) reported that athletes were better suited

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for endorsing an energy bar, compared with actors, but that athletes were not adequate endorsers for candy bars.

Source Credibility

The source-credibility model analyzes factors that contribute to the perceived credibility of the communicator. According to one author (Ohanian, 1990), expertise, trustworthiness, and physical attractiveness are the main factors driving individuals' perceptions of source credibility. The level of expertise refers to the extent to which the endorser is believed to be a valid source of information, whereas the trustworthiness denotes the perceived honesty, believability, and integrity of the endorser (Erdogan, 1999; Ohanian, 1990). Sources with high credibility are supposed to have a positive impact on consumer attitudes and behavior, and these sources therefore are desirable brand communicators (Erdogan, 1999; Mishra *et al.*, 2015).

Numerous authors have connected the match-up hypothesis and the source-credibility model in the context of celebrity endorsement, indicating that a perceived fit between the endorser and the brand leads to higher source credibility (Kamins, 1990; Kamins and Gupta, 1994; Koernig and Boyd, 2009; Mishra *et al.*, 2015). One such study compared the impact of attractive or unattractive celebrity endorsers on attractiveness-related or attractiveness-unrelated products (Kamins, 1990). An attractive celebrity who advertised an attractiveness-related product, such as a luxury car, was perceived as more credible,

compared with a less attractive celebrity endorsing the same product.

In another article concerning the effect of congruency on perceptions of the endorser, researchers reported higher levels of perceived believability and overall attractiveness after exposure to a fitting brand-endorser combination (Kamins and Gupta, 1994). Another study reported higher levels of perceived expertise, trust, and advertising effectiveness, as well as fewer negative thoughts concerning the advertisement, when there was a higher match between the endorser and the brand (Koernig and Boyd, 2009).

Still another study manipulated the congruency between the brand personality and the celebrity-endorser personality, using an extensive conceptual model to indicate the impact on the endorser's credibility and suitability and on the advertising dimensions (Mishra *et al.*, 2015). Again, source credibility was affected positively by the endorser-brand fit and, in turn, indirectly influenced relevant brand dimensions.

STUDY 1

Hypotheses Development

On the basis of the aforementioned studies (Kamins, 1990; Kamins and Gupta, 1994; Koernig and Boyd, 2009; Mishra *et al.*, 2015), as well as attributional theory and social-adaptation theory on the impact of the fit between the influencer and the brand, source credibility should be affected positively by high influencer-brand fit. Although the original source-credibility

model included the dimensions of trustworthiness, expertise, and physical attractiveness (Ohanian, 1990), the authors asked whether the fit between the influencer and the brand product might affect only perceptions of trustworthiness and expertise. Although physical attractiveness is without doubt an important factor in endorsement effectiveness, as has been shown in past work (*e.g.*, Bergkvist and Zhou, 2016; Eisend and Langner, 2010; Kamins, 1990; Till and Busler, 2000), the authors were unable to identify a study that could validate the theoretical or empirical influence of endorser-brand congruency on the perceived physical attractiveness of the endorser.

They identified four studies that analyzed the influence of endorser-brand congruency on source credibility, but these studies did not incorporate explicitly the construct of physical attractiveness. One study (Kamins, 1990) used only one item ("credible") to operationalize source credibility, and another (Kamins and Gupta, 1994) used a similar one-item approach. That study used the adjectives "believable" and "attractive" to measure endorser believability and general attractiveness, respectively. The authors did not specify what kind of attractiveness this meant; rather, in line with their theoretical assumptions (*i.e.*, "Although attractiveness impacts persuasion, its effects may be confounded with other source attributes such as spokesperson status and personality"; Kamins and Gupta, 1994, p. 572), they incorporated the overall attractiveness of the endorser's personality and did not limit the construct to physical attractiveness. A third study (Koernig and Boyd, 2009) analyzed only the impact of endorser-brand fit on the dimensions of expertise and trustworthiness, whereas the fourth (Mishra *et al.*, 2015) did not consider the three dimensions individually, instead using the complete source-credibility scale developed by previous research (Ohanian, 1990).

In the authors' view, and on the basis of the presented theories, there is no logical reason to assume that the fit between the influencer and the brand should have an impact on the perceived physical attractiveness of the endorser. The fit between the influencer and the brand, however, should alter media users' level of trust concerning the influencer's motives (trustworthiness) and perceived usability as an adequate source of information (expertise).

- H1: The fit between the influencer and the brand has a positive impact on perceived trustworthiness and expertise but does not affect the assessment of physical attractiveness significantly.

Credible communicators are believed to be persuasive brand ambassadors. Researchers have found a positive impact of expertise and source trustworthiness on relevant brand dimensions (Goldsmith, Lafferty, and Newell, 2000; Koernig and Boyd, 2009; Mishra *et al.*, 2015; Ohanian, 1990). A separate meta-analysis mentioned both trustworthiness and expertise among the most important factors in predicting celebrity-endorsement effectiveness (Amos *et al.*, 2008).

- H2: The level of influencer credibility positively affects the evaluation of the endorsed brand.

The connection between brand attitude and behavioral intentions has been validated empirically multiple times (*e.g.*, Goldsmith *et al.*, 2000; Mishra *et al.*, 2015). If consumers positively evaluate a brand, they should be more inclined to buy it, recommend it to friends, or display other kinds of behavior appraised as positive.

- H3: The more positively individuals evaluate a brand, the more likely

they are to indicate favorable behavioral intentions.

Aside from the aforementioned individual relationships among source credibility, brand attitude, and behavioral intentions, the authors believe that the fit between the influencer and the brand will affect the behavioral intentions of consumers. Expertise, for example, has been found to influence purchase intentions (Ohanian, 1991). In line with the theoretical background, heightened credibility and positive brand evaluations should be the cause of this effect.

- H4: The fit between the influencer and the brand has a positive impact on behavioral intentions. Perceived influencer credibility and brand attitudes mediate this effect.

METHODS

Design and Materials. To validate the postulated impact of influencer-brand fit on credibility and advertising effectiveness, the authors implemented in Germany an online experiment with a 2×1 between-subjects design. The authors manipulated the level of fit between the two experimental groups using a textual description of the Instagram influencer "matiamubysofia," who has about 500,000 followers. The textual manipulation described Sofia as either a German model who was excited about small, fast cars and interested in automobiles in general or as someone who was very environmentally conscious and preferred to use a bicycle rather than a car.

Afterward, individuals in both groups were shown three Instagram posts. The first and third posts depicted Sofia posing with a KIA Rio, actively promoting and praising the car. The second post simply showed Sofia standing on a bridge, not

promoting anything, to disguise the purpose of the study and raise the external validity of the created Instagram feed.

The authors chose the middle-class automobile brand KIA on the basis of the results of a study that analyzed the image strength of different brands in Germany (Möll, 2007). KIA was classified as a brand with a weak brand image, so individuals' beliefs about this brand should be affected relatively easily by advertising strategies. The Rio, a subcompact car, also should be relevant to a young audience active in social media because it is more affordable than cars made by companies such as BMW or Range Rover.

Procedure and Measurements. The participants were recruited on Facebook and Instagram. After they had been welcomed and provided with instructions for participating in the study, the participants were confronted randomly with either the high influencer-brand fit or the low influencer-brand fit description. After they had finished reading this short text, the three Instagram posts were presented successively (the Instagram posts used are available from the authors on request).

The participants were instructed to observe the Instagram posts as they usually would and to click on the "forward" button when they were finished. After the participants had seen all three Instagram posts, they were asked to rate the fit between the influencer and the brand using a scale introduced by previous researchers (Till and Busler, 2000; four items; $\alpha = .85$; $M = 3.84$, $SD = 1.17$). The participants were asked, for instance, to indicate on a 6-point Likert scale to what extent they believed that "Sofia is a suitable endorser for KIA."

After indicating the perceived fit between the influencer and the brand, the participants were asked to rate Sofia's credibility. The authors used the three dimensions of the source credibility scale

introduced by previous research (Ohanian, 1990): trustworthiness (five items; $\alpha = .91$; $M = 3.64$, $SD = 1.06$), expertise (five items; $\alpha = .87$; $M = 3.46$, $SD = 1.03$), and physical attractiveness (five items; $\alpha = .88$; $M = 4.70$, $SD = 0.84$). The authors also merged the dimensions of trustworthiness and expertise to obtain a credibility scale (10 items; $\alpha = .93$; $M = 3.55$, $SD = 0.99$) suitable for testing their hypotheses.

The participants rated their agreement on a 6-point Likert scale for items such as, “I believe Sofia to be a reliable person” (trustworthiness), “I think Sofia is competent” (expertise), and “I think Sofia is sexy” (physical attractiveness). To measure the impact of influencer–brand fit on brand evaluation (five items; $\alpha = .94$; $M = 3.21$, $SD = 1.19$) and behavioral intentions (five items; $\alpha = .91$; $M = 2.02$, $SD = 0.96$), the authors used 6-point Likert scales based on previous work (Spears and Singh, 2004, and Rössler, 2011, respectively). The participants indicated their agreement, for example, with the following statements: “I like KIA” (brand evaluation), and “I would recommend KIA to friends” (behavioral intention).

Participants. After exclusion of cases that were unusual or incomplete, as well as participants who did not use Instagram themselves, the final sample for the first study consisted of 687 volunteers. The majority (78 percent) were men and boys, and the total sample had a mean age of 21.23 ($SD = 4.96$) years and an age range of 12 to 55 years. About 57 percent indicated that they had completed high school or possessed a higher education degree. Approximately 5 percent had known about the influencer, Sofia, before participating in this study. The appropriate tests indicated no differences between the groups in terms of

- gender, $\chi^2(1, N = 687) = 1.48$, $p = .22$;
- age, $t(685) = -0.89$, $p = .37$;

TABLE 1

Means and Standard Deviations of the Two Groups in Study 1

Dependent variable	Low Influencer–Brand Fit ($n = 343$)		High Influencer–Brand Fit ($n = 344$)	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Expertise	3.33	0.99	3.59	1.06
Trustworthiness	3.48	1.06	3.79	1.04
Physical attractiveness	4.69	0.96	4.71	0.86
Source credibility	3.41	0.65	3.69	1.00
Brand attitude	3.09	1.15	3.32	1.22
Behavioral intentions	1.93	0.88	2.11	1.03

Note: $N = 687$. A 6-point Likert scale was employed.

- educational level, $\chi^2(5, N = 687) = 2.75$, $p = .74$; or
- prior exposure to the influencer, $\chi^2(1, N = 687) = 0.03$, $p = .86$.

Only 12 (2 percent) of the participants indicated that they owned a KIA car, and there was no difference between the groups on this factor, $\chi^2(1, N = 687) = 0.01$, $p = .98$.

Results and Discussion

Before testing the hypotheses, the authors performed a manipulation check to validate the different levels of influencer–brand fit. The participants exposed to the description of the influencer as knowledgeable and enthusiastic about cars evaluated her as more fitting to the brand ($M = 4.17$, $SD = 1.06$), compared with the second group, who were exposed to the less fitting description ($M = 3.52$, $SD = 1.19$). The difference between the two groups was significant, $t(675.25) = -7.59$, $p < .001$ (Cohen’s $d = 0.58$) (See Table 1).

To validate the first hypothesis, which postulated a positive impact of influencer–brand fit on source credibility, the authors performed independent t tests, analyzing the three dimensions of source credibility separately. As predicted, trustworthiness,

$t(687) = -3.86$, $p < .001$ (Cohen’s $d = 0.25$), and the level of expertise, $t(687) = -3.25$, $p < .001$ (Cohen’s $d = 0.30$) were perceived as higher if the brand matched the influencer. Also as predicted, the manipulation had no effect on the perception of the influencer’s physical attractiveness, $t(687) = -0.37$, ns . Consequently, the first hypothesis was supported.

The authors performed a serial mediation analysis to test the remaining three hypotheses. They used the PROCESS path-analysis macro for SPSS, a software package used for statistical analysis (based on Hayes, 2018, Model 6), and the bootstrapping method ($m = 10,000$). All of the reported regression coefficients were unstandardized.

In line with the aforementioned testing of the first hypothesis, the influencer’s credibility (trustworthiness and expertise combined) was affected significantly by the manipulation of influencer–brand fit ($b = .28$, $p < .001$). This already had been validated through the reported t test but nonetheless was included in the mediation model and presented to illustrate the complete model. Individuals’ perceived credibility had a positive effect on the evaluation of KIA ($b = .55$, $p < .001$); H2 therefore was

supported. As predicted, the brand evaluation, in turn, influenced behavioral intentions ($b = .57, p < .001$), supporting H3. The presumed indirect effect was positive and significant ($b = .09$; 90 percent confidence interval [CI] [.05, .13]), as was the total effect ($b = .18$, 90 percent CI [.06, .30]); H4 therefore was supported.

Because there was no direct effect ($b = .03$, *ns*) of the influencer–brand fit manipulation on behavioral intentions, the mediation can be considered complete (Hayes, 2018). The mediation model explained about 53 percent of the variance in the behavioral intentions concerning KIA. In sum, the results indicate a positive impact of influencer–brand fit, which can be explained by the higher perceived credibility of the influencer and the consequently favorable evaluation of the brand.

Although all four hypotheses were supported and the impact of fit between the brand and the influencer was confirmed, the external validity of the results is questionable because Study 1 did not reflect accurately the natural interaction with social-media influencers. The second study therefore incorporated familiar influencers and their impact on actual followers.

STUDY 2

The first study confirmed a positive effect of brand–influencer congruency on perceived source credibility. Another factor that should be of high importance for the perceived credibility of an endorser is the level of familiarity (Amos *et al.*, 2008; Chung and Cho, 2017; Gräve, 2017). Level of familiarity was found to be an important predictor of the impact of celebrity endorsements (Amos *et al.*, 2008).

Recent studies also have shown that consumers tend to trust familiar social-media influencers more strongly than less familiar social-media influencers (Chung and Cho, 2017; Gräve, 2017). The consumer's familiarity with the social-media influencer

might overshadow other elements, such as the perceived congruency between brand and influencer. In the literature, this phenomenon is called the halo effect (introduced by Thorndike, 1920). Individuals can create a positive halo around themselves, which can result in a blurring of other characteristics.

In a series of qualitative interviews concerning the halo effect in commercial-influencer communication, one research team (Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017) concluded that social-media users need to follow a social-media influencer for a reasonable time before they trust that person. After establishing a strong connection, they are willing to trust the social-media influencers they follow because they believe that the influencers “value their position of power and are unlikely to abuse it, therefore their opinions regarding a particular brand [...] would be considered credible” (p. 5).

This proposition also has been shown empirically. One study (Chung and Cho, 2017) incorporated participants' familiarity with the influencer into their research design, using the concept of parasocial relationship (Horton and Wohl, 1956; Schramm, 2008). The research validated that parasocial relationships increased the level of source trustworthiness, which, in turn, positively affected brand credibility and purchase intentions.

Parasocial Relationships As Positive Halo

Whereas parasocial interactions are the short-term, nonreciprocal interactions with media personalities (*e.g.*, movie characters, book figures, radio hosts), parasocial relationships are the long-term, cross-situational relationships that media users develop with media personalities over time (Horton and Wohl, 1956; Klimmt, Hartmann, and Schramm, 2006; Rubin and McHugh, 1987; Schramm, 2008). Like real

social relationships, parasocial relationships incorporate the development of complex cognitive character schemas (Perse and Rubin, 1989), resulting in a parasocial equivalent to friendship.

These media personalities consequently should be perceived as trustworthy, understanding, and responsible, and incoming character information with negative connotations might be dismissed more easily (Tukachinsky, 2010). This can be considered a “positive halo” (Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017). If higher levels of parasocial relationship actually could counterbalance lower levels of influencer–brand fit, both social-media influencers and brands could choose their prospective business partners more freely. This would enable new possibilities for cooperation.

Parasocial interactions and parasocial relationships with social-media influencers should be especially prominent and meaningful, compared with those with celebrities who appear only in traditional media (Chung and Cho, 2017; Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017; Yuksel and Labrecque, 2016). Social-media interactions take place regularly through channel subscription and incorporate some relatively newly developed options to get in touch with the influencer, such as commenting on, sharing, or liking their posts. This even offers some level of reciprocity, although the interaction remains unbalanced (Chung and Cho, 2017).

Influencers also should be perceived as similar to oneself, popular, and attractive (Djafarova and Rushworth, 2017). They share much personal information with their followers and often address them directly (Chung and Cho, 2017). All of these factors have been found to contribute positively to the intensity of parasocial interactions, which, in turn, should result in strong and steady parasocial relationships (Chung and Cho, 2017; Horton and Wohl, 1956; Klimmt *et al.*, 2006; Rubin

and McHugh, 1987; Schramm, 2008; Schramm and Hartmann, 2008). On the basis of previous research on parasocial relationships, it is possible that the effect of influencer-brand fit will be diminished if social-media users already have established a strong parasocial relationship with the influencer before observing the advertisement.

Parasocial relationship already has been identified as a factor that positively influences source credibility, on the basis of former experiences with the influencer and prior knowledge about his or her expertise and trustworthiness (Chung and Cho, 2017; Gräve, 2017; Mishra *et al.*, 2015). Because of multiple parasocial interactions and the subsequent parasocial relationships, a positive cognitive character schema and positive halo (*e.g.*, an influencer is characterized as trustworthy and reliable) should be prevalent, and negative information, such as low influencer-brand fit, might be dismissed more easily and not be as impactful (Tukachinsky, 2010). The perceived fit between the influencer and the brand therefore might be less critical for judging the influencer's credibility.

Research Questions

These reflections contradict the established perceptions of the match-up, congruency, and fit research on testimonials and therefore are presented as research questions.

RQ1: Do high levels of parasocial relationship diminish the impact of the perceived fit between the influencer and the brand?

Because of the moderating effect of parasocial relationship, the effect of influencer-brand fit through perceived credibility and brand attitudes on behavioral intentions identified in the first study might vary in intensity.

The results indicate a positive impact of influencer-brand fit, which can be explained by the higher perceived credibility of the influencer and the consequently favorable evaluation of the brand.

RQ2: Will the indirect effect of the perceived fit on behavioral intentions found in the first study be stronger for individuals who report low levels of parasocial relationship, compared with those who report high levels of parasocial relationship?

Methods

Design and Materials. In contrast to the first study, the second study did not use an experimental design to manipulate the level of fit between the influencer and the brand. The authors believed that it would be more accurate for participants to estimate the influencer-brand fit without textual information, because this seemed to represent the natural environment more closely. Consequently, the authors employed a survey and asked individuals about influencers they already knew and followed. Participants could choose one of three influencers who were known widely in Germany and considered some of the most successful social-media influencers (Statista.com, 2018):

- Stefanie Giesinger (stefaniegiesinger), who has 3.3 million followers and is considered a lifestyle influencer and a fashion model;
- Pamela Reif (pamela_rf), who specializes in healthy foods and sports and has 3.9 million followers; and
- Caroline Daur (carodaur), who has 1.6 million followers on Instagram and describes herself as a fashion blogger.

After selecting one of these influencers, participants completed an individually adapted survey. The authors decided to incorporate three different influencers with divergent areas of expertise to improve the generalizability of the results and gain more participants. Potential participants who did not follow any of the three influencers were considered unsuitable for the survey and therefore were not selected for participation.

This study incorporated the fashion brand FILA as the research object because beauty and fashion topics are among the most common themes and areas of expertise of social-media influencers in Germany (Linqia, 2018; Statista.com, 2018). The authors also decided to use this familiar and established brand because they wanted to generalize the results of the first study, which incorporated an automobile brand with a weak brand image. The participants in this second study indicated that they knew FILA very well, even before taking part in this survey ($M = 5.18$, $SD = 1.47$, on a 7-point Likert scale), which points toward high brand familiarity and a strong brand image.

The authors edited a picture that showed the individually selected influencer wearing a white shirt with the FILA brand logo printed on the front. The authors actively selected three Instagram photos that were as similar to each other as possible and then added the logo onto the influencers' shirts (the Instagram posts used are available from the authors on request).

Procedure and Measurements. As in the first study, participants were recruited on Instagram and Facebook. After they had been welcomed and informed about the procedure, participants were asked to choose one of the three influencers whom they followed on Instagram. The friendship dimensions of the Multiple Parasocial Relationships Scale (developed by Tukachinsky, 2010) then were employed to measure the participants' levels of parasocial relationship concerning the selected influencer. In total, 13 items were presented, and participants indicated their level of agreement on a 7-point Likert scale ($\alpha = .94$; $M = 3.78$, $SD = 1.33$). For instance, the participants rated how likely they were to share personal information with the influencer.

After the level of parasocial relationship was measured, the Instagram post was presented to verify the impact of perceived influencer-brand fit on advertising effectiveness. If a participant selected Stefanie Giesinger, for example, the parasocial relationship items displayed incorporated Ms. Giesinger's name in their wording, and the Instagram post showed her wearing a white FILA shirt. The participants were asked to rate the perceived credibility of their selected influencer after observing the Instagram post. As in the first study, the two source-credibility dimensions (trustworthiness and expertise; from Ohanian's, 1990, scale) were used and merged (10 items; $\alpha = .90$; $M = 5.16$, $SD = 0.90$).

After the participants had assessed the influencer's credibility, they were asked to rate the brand-influencer fit (four items; $\alpha = .85$; $M = 3.84$, $SD = 1.17$), evaluate the FILA brand (five items; $\alpha = .91$; $M = 5.27$, $SD = 1.21$), and indicate levels of behavioral intentions (three items; $\alpha = .88$; $M = 3.49$, $SD = 1.46$). In line with the first study, these items were based on the work of previous researchers (Till and Busler, 2000, Spears and Singh, 2004, and Rössler, 2011, respectively).

Participants. After the exclusion of unusual and incomplete cases, the final sample for the second study consisted of 197 volunteers. The majority (92 percent) were women and girls, and the total sample had a mean age of 21.06 ($SD = 5.61$) years and an age range of 13 to 52 years. About 70 percent indicated that they had completed high school or possessed a higher education degree.

Nearly all of the participants reported that they used Instagram at least once per day (98 percent) or once per week (2 percent) and had been following their selected influencer for several years (56.9 percent), months (35.5 percent), or weeks (5.6 percent). Only a few participants had started following the influencer more recently (3 percent). Participants also were asked whether they had purchased FILA brand products before participating in this study, because former purchase behavior is an important factor in future brand choice. Approximately 44 percent of the participants never or only occasionally (30 percent) had purchased FILA brand products, but about 26 percent were regular customers. Former purchase behavior consequently was included as a covariate in the following analysis.

Results and Discussion

A serial moderated mediation model (See Table 2) was calculated with PROCESS Macro 3.0 (Hayes, 2018; Model 83). Again, all of the reported regression coefficients were unstandardized, and the bootstrapping method ($m = 10,000$) was employed. Typically, one standard deviation above and below the mean of the moderator is used to indicate high- and low-level conditioning. Here, conditional effects of perceived fit on credibility were calculated for low (reported value = 2.44), average (reported value = 3.78), and high (reported value = 5.11) levels of the moderator, parasocial relationship.

As presumed, there was a significant negative interaction between perceived fit and reported parasocial relationship ($b = -.04$, $p < .05$). Participants with low levels of parasocial relationship ($b = .24$, 90 percent CI [.16, .31]) reported the highest influence of perceived fit on source credibility, followed by individuals who indicated average ($b = .18$, 90 percent CI [.12, .24]) and high levels ($b = .13$, 90 percent CI [.04, .21]) of parasocial relationship.

In line with the halo-effect theory (Thorn-dike, 1920), individuals who reported lower levels of parasocial relationship more likely used perceived fit as a heuristic to gauge the credibility of the influencer. Participants who reported a strong relationship with the influencer were not influenced as strongly by perceived fit, most likely because they based their assessment of the influencer at least partially on past experiences and the existing parasocial relationship. The authors want to stress, nonetheless, that the influence of perceived fit on credibility was still significant. Parasocial relationship consequently could not diminish completely the impact of perceived fit.

The second research question considered parasocial relationship as a moderator of Study 1's indirect effect of perceived fit on behavioral intentions through source credibility and brand evaluation. The reported credibility of the influencer had a significant impact on the evaluation of the FILA brand ($b = .51$, $p < .001$), which, in turn, had a significant positive effect on behavioral intentions ($b = .55$, $p < .001$). The indirect effect decreased with the level of reported parasocial relationship and was consequently stronger for participants with low levels of parasocial relationship ($b = .06$, 90 percent CI [.03, .10]), compared with those with average ($b = .05$, 90 percent CI [.02, .08]) or high levels ($b = .03$, 90 percent CI [.01, .06]) of parasocial relationship.

There also were significant direct effects of both perceived fit ($b = .20$, $p <$

TABLE 2

Study 2: Serial Mediation Analysis with Unstandardized Regression Coefficients and Bootstrapping ($m = 10,000$; Hayes, 2018)

Outcome	<i>B</i>	<i>SE B</i>	<i>t</i>	<i>p</i>
Credibility				
Constant	2.15 [1.43, 2.86]	0.43	4.97	<.001
Perceived fit	0.33 [0.18, 0.48]	0.09	3.67	<.001
Parasocial relationship	0.58 [0.39, 0.78]	0.12	4.84	<.001
Perceived fit $\times$ Parasocial relationship	−0.04 [−0.08, −0.01]	0.02	−1.66	<.05
Former purchase behavior	−0.02 [−0.05, 0.01]	0.02	−0.99	ns
<i>Conditional indirect effects of X on Y at values of the moderator</i>				
Low levels of parasocial relationship (value = 2.44)	0.24 [0.16, 0.31]	0.04	5.22	<.001
Average levels of parasocial relationship (value = 3.78)	0.19 [0.12, 0.24]	0.04	4.95	<.001
High levels of parasocial relationship (value = 5.11)	0.13 [0.04, 0.21]	0.06	2.30	<.05
Brand attitude (FILA)				
Constant	1.09 [0.41, 1.77]	0.41	2.66	<.01
Perceived fit	0.29 [0.18, 0.39]	0.06	4.54	<.001
Credibility	0.51 [0.36, 0.65]	0.09	5.62	<.001
Former purchase behavior	0.06 [0.01, 0.11]	0.03	1.95	<.05
Behavioral intention (FILA)				
Constant	−1.54 [−2.30, −0.78]	0.45	−3.34	<.001
Perceived fit	0.20 [0.08, 0.32]	0.07	2.74	<.01
Credibility	0.19 [0.01, 0.36]	0.11	1.74	<.05
Brand attitude	0.49 [0.36, 0.62]	0.08	6.16	<.001
Former brand purchase	0.19 [0.13, 0.24]	0.04	5.33	<.001
<i>Conditional indirect effects of X on Y at values of the moderator</i>				
Low levels of parasocial relationship (value = 2.44)	0.06 [0.03, 0.10]	0.02		
Average levels of parasocial relationship (value = 3.78)	0.05 [0.02, 0.08]	0.02		
High levels of parasocial relationship (value = 5.11)	0.03 [0.01, 0.06]	0.02		

Note: $R^2 = .48$. Former purchase behavior was used as a covariate. Index of moderated mediation = $-.01$, 90 percent confidence interval (CI) $[-.03, -.001]$.

.01) and source credibility ($b = .19, p < .05$) on behavioral intentions. The model explained 48 percent of the variance in individuals' behavioral intentions. All indirect effects were significant, and although they decreased with the intensity of parasocial relationship (index of moderated mediation = $-.01$, 90 percent CI [$-.03, -.001$]), parasocial relationship still could not diminish completely the importance of the perceived fit.

GENERAL DISCUSSION

Implications

The first study presented here causally validated the presumed impact of congruency between the influencer and the advertised brand. When the participants were given information stating that the influencer liked and was knowledgeable about automobiles, they believed her to be more trustworthy and to have higher expertise, but they did not evaluate her as more physically attractive.

Social-adaptation theory and attribution theory were used to explain this effect; the matching endorser was believed to be a valid source of information and internally motivated rather than driven by endorsement fees. The KIA brand consequently was evaluated more positively when levels of perceived source credibility were higher. Higher levels of perceived source credibility, in turn, led to higher indications of positive behavioral intentions.

The second study validated this mechanism in a more authentic scenario and included parasocial relationship as a moderator of the indirect effect. Participants who indicated high levels of parasocial relationship less likely based their assessment of the influencer's credibility on perceived fit; rather, they were inclined more to use their former experiences as an indication. This moderation had an effect on the entire model, because the indirect effect decreased with the level of reported parasocial

Although it might seem lucrative to accept an offer from a major brand, if it clearly does not fit the influencer's image, it would be better to decline the cooperation.

relationship and was consequently strongest for participants with low levels of parasocial relationship.

Even though the index of moderated mediation of the complete model was small, it was still significant. The indirect effect nonetheless was positive and significant for all levels of the moderator, parasocial relationship. This is a practically relevant contribution of the study that enables the authors to give concrete advice for both influencers and brand managers.

In general, influencers should advertise brands that seem to fit their area of expertise and interest, especially if they have started their career recently and have not established strong parasocial relationships with their followers yet, or if they have a considerable and continuous increase of new followers. Although it might seem lucrative to accept an offer from a major brand, if it clearly does not fit the influencer's image, it would be better to decline the cooperation. Otherwise, the influencer's perceived expertise and trustworthiness might suffer, which, in turn, could reduce his or her likability and engagement rate in the long term (Koernig and Boyd, 2009).

An earlier study demonstrated that the number of "likes" influences perceived popularity and opinion leadership (DeVeirman *et al.*, 2017), indicating that this process could lead to a downward spiral. This is the case for a strong mismatch between the influencer and the brand. Both the Volvo case study mentioned earlier and the manipulation

used in this study are examples of strong discrepancies.

This study's textual manipulation stated explicitly that the influencer preferred to ride her bike, and shortly afterward the participants were presented with an Instagram feed incorporating cars. Given this strong manipulation of brand-influencer mismatch, the reported effect sizes and the difference between groups were rather small (See Table 2). Consequently, a popular and well-established influencer might be able to endorse a brand that does not perfectly match his or her profile, but the influencer still should be cautious and try to incorporate high levels of authenticity into his or her posts to elicit high levels of parasocial interactions and parasocial relationship (*e.g.*, by addressing the audience directly and telling a personal story). Of course, this theory should be validated empirically, especially because the level of authenticity could be influenced easily by the guidelines of the brand manager or advertising specialist.

The findings are also of high relevance for brand managers, because the second study showed that perceived fit did not influence only the influencer's credibility; it also had a significant direct effect on brand attitude and behavioral intentions. This means that perceived fit affected the brand not only through the influencer's image but also directly. Selecting a nonmatching influencer consequently might be even worse for the brand than for the endorser's image. If one looks at it the other way around, using a matching influencer is beneficial for brand

attitude and behavioral intentions, both directly and indirectly.

Another factor that advertisers should take note of is that source credibility did have a strong and direct impact on both brand attitude and behavioral intentions. The credibility of an influencer was determined not only by the congruency between the endorser and the brand but also by many different elements (e.g., levels of parasocial interactions and parasocial relationship, familiarity). If possible, advertising specialists should urge social-media influencers to create a particularly personal post, such as incorporating a personal story or addressing the followers very directly, when the influencer-brand fit is only mediocre. Choosing highly credible influencers or at least creating highly credible posts should be beneficial for both the brand's image and behavioral intentions reported by potential customers.

Limitations and Future Research

Although the combination of both studies presented here creates additional value, there are some aspects of this approach that may be criticized. The first study provided results high in internal validity, whereas the second study used a survey without explicitly manipulating the fit between the brand and the influencer. The direction of effects consequently cannot be ascertained beyond doubt. The authors still could indicate a direction on the basis of the results of the first study, but it would be beneficial to replicate the second study using an experimental design. The manipulated Instagram posts could show the familiar influencer with either a congruent or an incongruent brand to validate the impact on credibility. Naturally, the parasocial relationship with the familiar influencer must be included as a moderator in the experimental model.

Additionally, future studies should try to replicate the reported results using divergent types of social-media influencer,

including more diverse brands, and incorporating different settings (e.g., other social-media platforms, such as Snapchat or Facebook) to generalize the findings. Although some level of generalizability is possible because of the incorporation of two different brand products (KIA Rio versus FILA), diverse samples, and four social-media influencers, a wider representation still is needed to enable universally valid recommendations.

The current studies have contributed to the body of knowledge on influencer marketing, but other factors should be considered in future research. Elements of individuals' long-term bonding with influencers, such as parasocial relationship or identification in general, should be analyzed. As the second study was able to show, long-term bonding decreases the effects of other potential factors (e.g., the perceived influencer-brand fit). To what extent the impact of other, already studied elements, such as the number of followers (DeVeirman *et al.*, 2017) or negative information about an endorser (Amos *et al.*, 2008), decreases or even increases because of long-term attachment should be studied in future research.

Additionally, well-known factors that influence parasocial relationship in other media contexts, such as the level of perceived similarity or the direct addressing of the audience, should be incorporated into research on social-media influencers to verify these factors' relevance. The manipulation of these factors and the impact on brand dimensions could provide indications of how to choose the influencer best suited for the target group of the advertised brand. Given that the relevance of influencer recommendations is growing steadily in current marketing practice, the authors are curious to see how advertising research will adjust and produce substantial suggestions for practitioners. 

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